From the Development of *Future Drama* to the Emergence of *Theatrical Ethics*

Lv, Dan*

Abstract

Any discussion of *future drama* must begin with the potential transformation of its core element—the human subject. Such transformation is an inevitable consequence of contemporary technological development. On this basis, the trajectory of future drama may be anticipated along two principal lines: the digitalization of thought and the digitalization of form. These developments will expand the participatory dimension of future drama to an unprecedented level and elevate its experiential intensity beyond that of traditional theatrical practice.

Equally significant, however, is the emergence of inherent ethical tensions within future drama. This article introduces and defines the concept of *theatrical ethics* and examines how ethical contradictions—arising from post-human evolution and technologically mediated artistic practices—will inevitably accompany the development of future drama. By articulating these theoretical concerns, the article seeks to contribute to a deeper understanding of the conceptual, ethical, and aesthetic challenges that future drama is likely to confront.

Keywords: future drama; digitalization; theatrical ethics; participation; experience

Introduction

In the brief two decades since humanity entered the twenty-first century, modern technologies—driven by digitalization, artificial intelligence, life sciences, new energy applications, and high-speed communication systems—have advanced at an unprecedented pace, producing profound transformations in human society. These changes have begun to disrupt the underlying logic of social organization and continue to accelerate. As a fundamental cultural form accompanying human civilization, drama cannot remain unaffected; it must undergo corresponding transformations in order to adapt to these evolving conditions. This interdependence between drama and civilization operates independently of human will. Against this background, inquiry into *future drama* acquires immediate theoretical and practical significance.[1]

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* Lv Dan is Associate Professor in the School of Chinese Opera, Shanghai Theatre Academy, Shanghai, China.

[1] Klaus Schwab, *The Fourth Industrial Revolution* (New York: Crown Business, 2017), 1–12.

One influential view maintains that because drama is fundamentally human-centered—whether in characters, playwrights, performers, audiences, or directors—it will inevitably preserve its traditional ontology regardless of technological change. According to this perspective, future drama will continue either to reflect social problems or to express human thought, ultimately returning to the essential core of traditional drama.[2]

While this argument is logically coherent, it rests on a critical presupposition: that the human of the future remains identical to the human as traditionally understood. If this premise no longer holds, the conclusion must be reconsidered.

Recent technological developments have rendered this question unavoidable. Human cloning has become technically feasible, though currently restricted by ethical and legal constraints. Brain–computer interface technology has entered substantive clinical trials, enabling direct neural control of electronic systems.[3] Gene-editing technologies have likewise achieved success in medical treatment and promise further interventions into human biology. In the foreseeable future, humans may acquire immunity to disease, enhanced bodily repair, integration with machines, and radically expanded sensory and cognitive capacities. Can such beings still be regarded as human in the traditional sense?

Marshall McLuhan once observed that humanity is increasingly translated into information, approaching the technological extension of consciousness.[4] If so, will the emotional core inherited by humanity persist in future beings? And on what grounds can we continue to assume that future drama will remain anchored in traditional dramatic foundations if its genetic core—the human subject—has fundamentally changed?

As human beings transform, so too does the environment in which they exist. Artificial intelligence and networked systems are reshaping relationships among humans, between humans and machines, and even among machines themselves. Under such conditions, the notion that drama will change only superficially becomes increasingly untenable. It is precisely from these considerations that the exploration of future drama derives its urgency.

I. Developmental Prospects of *Future Drama*

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[2] Erika Fischer-Lichte, *The Transformative Power of Performance* (London: Routledge, 2008), 22–30.

[3] Nita A. Farahany, *The Battle for Your Brain* (New York: St. Martin's Press, 2023), 43–58.

[4] Marshall McLuhan, *Understanding Media* (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1964), 57–65.

Understanding the development of future drama rests on two foundational conditions. First, technological advancement is transforming human beings themselves. Biological sciences promise changes in longevity, disease resistance, and physical capacity, while digital technologies enhance cognition and the capacity to manipulate external systems. Second, technology is reshaping the environments in which humans live, including infrastructure, social organization, and interpersonal relationships.

From these conditions, two conclusions follow: future drama will undergo the digitalization of thought, and it will manifest digitalized forms. Consequently, participation in future drama will expand to an entirely new level, and theatrical experience will reach unprecedented intensity.

1. The Digitalization of Thought

Francis Fukuyama has warned that contemporary biotechnology may alter human nature itself, ushering in a post-human stage of history.[5] Once post-humans acquire capacities that appear miraculous by current standards, their modes of thought and cognitive logic will inevitably change. Birth, aging, illness, and death may cease to function as inescapable limits. Thought itself may be converted into digital form, enabling a form of digital persistence or "immortality".

Under such conditions, post-human value systems and cognitive frameworks will no longer conform to existing human models. Thought may adapt to a predominantly digital environment, manifesting reduced emotional depth, binary judgment structures, or redefined concepts of life itself. As the core element of drama—the human subject—undergoes this transformation, future drama will necessarily reflect this digitalization at the conceptual level.[6]

This shift is already foreshadowed in everyday behavior. Digital habits reveal an internalized computational logic. The digitalization of thought implies a cognitive orientation toward mathematical reasoning, potentially diminishing human traits traditionally regarded as weaknesses yet essential to artistic creation—emotion, desire, playfulness, and free will. Their disappearance or mutation would deprive future drama of the very variables that generate artistic vitality.

2. The Digitalization of Form

Digital experimentation has already appeared on contemporary stages. AI-driven improvisational performances and online interactive productions demonstrate new theatrical possibilities enabled by technology.[7] Throughout history, drama has never developed independently of its

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[5] Francis Fukuyama, *Our Posthuman Future* (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2002), 1–17.

[6] Rosi Braidotti, *The Posthuman* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2013), 13–29.

[7] Steve Dixon, *Digital Performance* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2007), 3–20.

technological and cultural environment. There is therefore no reason to doubt that digitalization will play a central role in the formal expression of future drama, even if its precise forms remain unpredictable.[8]

3. Expanded Participation

Early experiments in future drama reveal participation as a defining feature. Through technological mediation, the "fourth wall" is effectively dismantled. Performance becomes a collective act in which performers and spectators merge into a unified process.[9] Technological participation extends the body, senses, and consciousness of participants, reshaping psychological experience and theatrical perception.[10]

4. Intensified Experience

Technological mediation grants future drama unprecedented representational power. Simulation may approach near-perfect fidelity, extending beyond visual effects to multisensory immersion and spatial reconstruction.[11] Yet the dissolution of boundaries between reality and illusion carries latent risks. As Jean Baudrillard observes, the virtual offers pleasure by eliminating external referents, giving everything while subtly depriving the subject of everything.[12] Under hyper-real immersive conditions, audiences may experience cognitive disorientation or addiction-like dependence. Such outcomes warrant serious ethical concern.

II. The Emergence of *Theatrical Ethics*

1. Defining *Theatrical Ethics*

Theatrical ethics is not an established term. As proposed here, it refers to the ethical and axiological dimensions condensed and reflected within dramatic art. Drama conveys the ethical

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[8] Johannes Birringer, *Performance, Technology, and Science* (New York: PAJ Publications, 2008), 89–104.

[9] Jacques Rancière, *The Emancipated Spectator* (London: Verso, 2009), 2–15.

[10] Philip Auslander, *Liveness* (London: Routledge, 2008), 24–39.

[11] Oliver Grau, *Virtual Art* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2003), 191–210.

[12] Jean Baudrillard, *The Intelligence of Evil* (London: Bloomsbury Academic, 2013), 82–89.

standards of its creators while simultaneously refracting the diverse value systems of its historical moment. When conflicts between these dimensions are not internalized as dramatic tension but instead manifest as genuine contradictions, they reveal conflicts of values, beliefs, and worldviews.[13]

Ethical systems are historically contingent and culturally diverse. This diversity provides the structural basis for ethical conflict, which manifests externally as theatrical ethics.

2. Historical Precedents

Ethical conflict has long accompanied drama and related media. Numerous theatrical and cinematic works have provoked moral, political, and aesthetic controversy, often resulting in censorship or prohibition.[14] These cases demonstrate the persistent tension between artistic expression and prevailing ethical frameworks.

3. *Theatrical Ethics* in Future Drama

In future drama, ethical contradictions will be especially pronounced. The emergence of post-humans introduces potential conflicts between enhanced beings and unmodified humans. Digital social norms will collide with traditional customs, and post-human belief systems may diverge radically from inherited spiritual frameworks.[15]

Although current theatrical experiments integrate technology primarily as an external enhancement, fully realized future drama—guided by genuinely post-human cognition—has yet to emerge. Hypothetical inquiry nonetheless allows us to anticipate ethical dilemmas: discrimination by post-humans, the status of virtual performers, the distinction between AI-generated likenesses and human originals, and the acceptability of hyper-realistic negative characters.[16] Even if speculative, these scenarios point to an unavoidable conclusion: theatrical ethics will accompany the development of future drama as one of its defining characteristics.

Conclusion

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[13] Alasdair MacIntyre, *After Virtue* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1981), 204–25.

[14] Ibid.

[15] Donna J. Haraway, *Simians, Cyborgs, and Women* (New York: Routledge, 1991), 149–81.

[16] Mark Coeckelbergh, *AI Ethics* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2020), 97–112.

Based on a reasoned assessment of contemporary technological trajectories, this study identifies the transformation of the human subject as the core driver of future drama. The digitalization of thought and form will elevate participation and experience to unprecedented levels. Alongside these developments, theatrical ethics will inevitably arise from the structural contradictions inherent in post-human evolution.

The exploration of future drama will be a long—and perhaps unending—process. Yet as art continually moves from the known toward the unknown, inquiry into future drama and its ethical implications will remain both necessary and unavoidable.[17]

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[17] Hans Ulrich Gumbrecht, *Production of Presence* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2004), 17–31.

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